TEARDOWN · A 5-PERSON AGENCY, [MONTH] 2026

$2,310

a month. That was the software bill.

We rebuilt the same stack for $47. Two swaps were a pain.

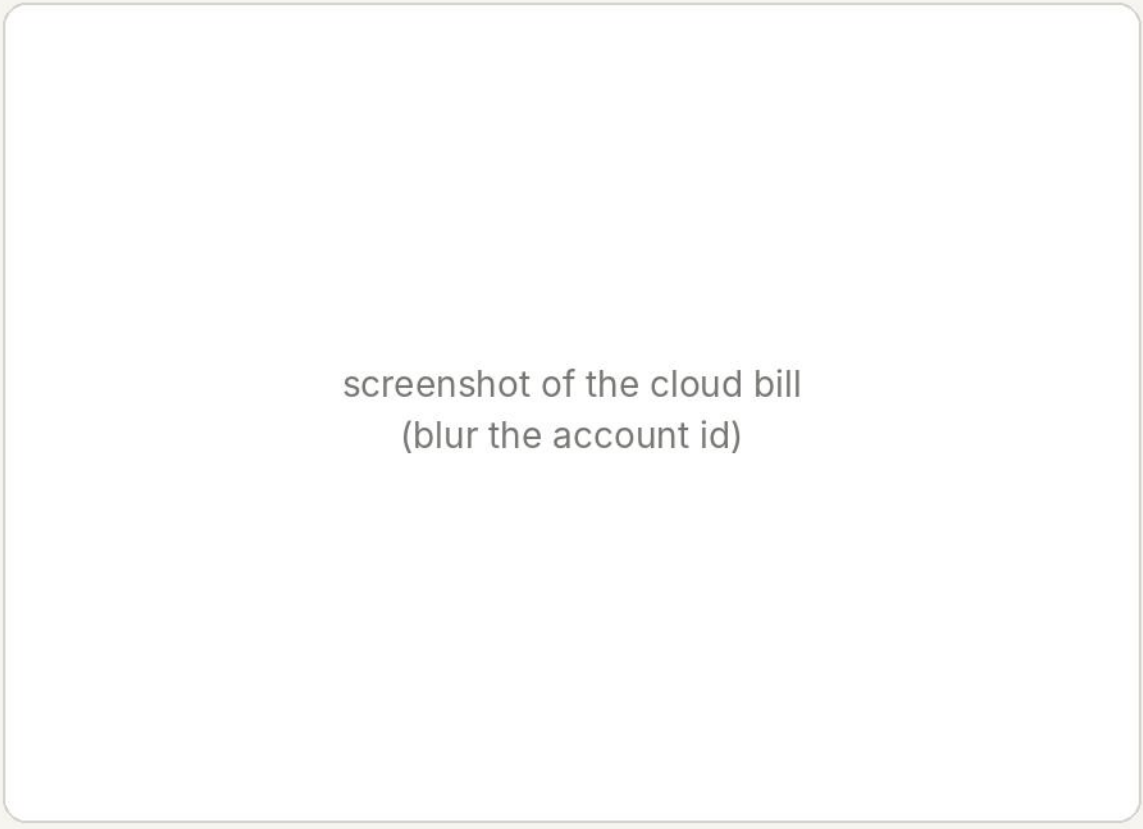
Every line, what replaced it, what we kept, what annoyed us.

$47

a month, after

WHERE IT STARTED

The billing page nobody had opened since [2024].



$1,621 of the $2,310 was on-demand cloud for workloads that fit on one small box. This slide is most of the story.

`captured [date]`

SWAP 1 · HOSTING

WAS

AWS, on-demand

~~$1,621~~

per month

NOW

One Hetzner box

$6

per month

YOU KEEP

- ✓ The CRM, the inbox and the AI chat all run on it
- ✓ Backups to object storage, about $1 a month

YOU GIVE UP

- – Someone else's uptime. It died once in [month], [3 hours]
- – Autoscaling we never used

about $19,000 a year

SWAP 2 · SUPPORT INBOX

WAS

Intercom Essential

~~$390~~

per month

NOW

Chatwoot

$0

per month

YOU KEEP

- ✓ Website chat, email, Instagram, in an afternoon
- ✓ WhatsApp, after [two evenings] and one forum thread
- ✓ AI answers from our help docs

YOU GIVE UP

- – Product tours. If you use them, skip this swap
- – The Intercom badge clients recognise

about $4,680 a year

SWAP 3 · CRM

WAS

HubSpot Starter, 5 seats

~~$90~~

per month

NOW

Twenty (open source)

$0

per month

YOU KEEP

- ✓ Pipeline, contacts, tasks. CSV import worked first time
- ✓ Email sync, after [40 min] of Gmail permission screens

YOU GIVE UP

- – HubSpot's marketing tools, which we weren't using
- – Certainty past 20 seats. Haven't tested it

about $1,080 a year

SWAP 4 · FORMS

WAS

Typeform Plus

~~$59~~

per month

NOW

Tally Pro

$29

per month

YOU KEEP

- ✓ Logic, Stripe payments, file uploads
- ✓ Completion rate within [a point] over [3 weeks]

YOU GIVE UP

- – Video questions
- – A slightly nicer-looking form. Clients haven't mentioned it

about $360 a year

SWAP 5 · TEAM AI

WAS

ChatGPT Team, 5 seats

~~$150~~

per month

NOW

Open WebUI + API credits

~$12

per month

YOU KEEP

- ✓ One chat window for everyone, document upload
- ✓ Choice of model. We're on [model] this month

YOU GIVE UP

- – The admin console and SSO
- – A fixed bill. One [400-page PDF] week cost more than the month before

about $1,650 a year

ALL FIVE, SIDE BY SIDE

Monthly, before and after. Give or take, depends on your plan.

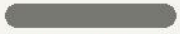
Hosting



$1,621 AWS

$6 Hetzner

Support inbox



$390 Intercom

$0 Chatwoot

Team AI, 5 seats



$150 ChatGPT Team

$12 Open WebUI

CRM



$90 HubSpot

$0 Twenty

Forms



$59 Typeform

$29 Tally

We could have stopped after the hosting line and saved 70%. We didn't, because once you start it's hard to stop.

IF YOU WANT TO COPY IT

What we actually did, in order

01 Rented the smallest Hetzner box, about $6. Took ten minutes.

02 Installed Docker, started Twenty. The make command does most of it.

```
git clone twentyhq/twenty && make up
```

03 Started Chatwoot on the same box. Then spent [two evenings] on WhatsApp.

```
docker compose up -d
```

04 Imported the HubSpot CSV, added the chat widget, ran both stacks in parallel for [two weeks], then cancelled.

About a weekend plus the WhatsApp evenings. Skills needed: copy, paste, patience.

THE HONEST BIT



If the $6 box dies on a Saturday, that's our Saturday. For $2,263 a month, we'll take the Saturday.

— Lean Stack

One swap a day. Free when it's good enough, cheap when it isn't.

Next week's teardown is yours if you send a bill. Blur the company name. Form and all the links are in the first comment.

Subscribe to The Swap List